A few insights help us assess the potential of the threat of modern terrorism. The basic premise, which must be clear to anyone dealing with this subject, is related to the historical development of Islam. Many aspects of the religion of Islam are drawn from Judaism and Christianity. It originated in the desert of the Arabian Peninsula in the seventh century and succeeded in rising up and conquering half of the world and establishing an empire that was an Arab caliphate. The Muslim conquerors succeeded in spreading the new religion, whether by persuasion or by coercion, throughout the caliphate. Islam prospered economically, culturally, and scientifically and made a significant contribution to humanity at that time. The empire of Islam continued to survive in the form of the Ottoman Empire until the First World War, when it suffered a humiliating defeat; after approximately 1,300 years of power and splendor, it was shattered to pieces by the Western colonial powers. Against this background one can and must understand the depth and intensity of the longing to restore Islam to its former status and realize that the strongest glue that connects people is neither politics nor society nor economic status but religious solidarity.

In discussing the potential of the threat of modern terrorism, we must understand the implications of the ultimate goal of establishing a global Muslim caliphate. In order to establish such a caliphate it is first necessary to conquer the world and Islamize its inhabitants; there must be a war of "Gog and Magog" following the resurrection of the *Mahdi* (a motif that is analogous to the Messiah in Judaism). Here we can highlight a fundamental difference between the followers of al-Qaeda and those of ISIS, despite the fact that the latter organization is an outgrowth of the former. Al-Qaeda members adhere to the scenario described above, as it appears in the canon of Shiite Islam, while ISIS followers believe that the issue can be forced—that it is necessary and possible to establish the world caliphate alongside the struggle against the infidels. And indeed, the leader of ISIS declared the conquest of the city of Raqqa in Syria as the beginning of the establishment of the caliphate; any additional territory occupied by ISIS—with no need for territorial contiguity—would declare its inclusion in the caliphate (for example, the Sinai Province in the Sinai Peninsula or Boko Haram in Nigeria).

Because the establishment of the Islamic caliphate is a divine commandment, so is everything that is derived from it. When a person acts according to a divine commandment, human reason (*ratio)*does not come